Behind the Curtain:

The Struggles and Scandals Shaping Indian Football's Future

Dungar Patel|BA(J&MC)IV

"In 2024, the Indian men's football team faced an incredibly tough year. Under coach Igor Stimac, the squad entered the year with high hopes of doing well in the AFC Asian Cup. But despite their determination, the team ended up with a series of frustrating results—11 matches, with only four goals to their name, six losses, and five draws. The crushing defeat against Afghanistan in the World Cup qualifiers was a low point, leaving fans heartbroken and questioning the team's future."

Indian football is at a turning point, caught between moments of fleeting hope and years of unfulfilled promises. It's a story of passionate fans, dedicated players, and a system struggling to overcome its own shortcomings. For many, it's a dream to see the Indian national football team rise to the level of international giants, but for now, it feels like a distant aspiration, a hope that's often overshadowed by disappointments.

For Indian football, this wasn't just a loss on the pitch; it was a reflection of the deep-rooted issues that continue to hold the sport back in the country. Players, coaches, and fans all shared the same frustration, but the question remained: why couldn't Indian football seem to break through?

After the disaster of 2024, the *All India Football Federation (AIFF)* made a bold move. They parted ways with Stimac and appointed Manolo Marquez, a seasoned coach who had previously been successful in the *Indian Super League (ISL)* with FC Goa. Marquez's arrival signaled a shift in mindset, and though the results under him weren't immediate, there was a noticeable change in style. The team, once known for its stiff and defensive approach, began playing with more fluidity and ambition. Players like *"Farukh Chaudhary and Irfan Yadwad"*, who had shone brightly in the ISL, were brought into the national squad, adding energy and urgency to the game.

But even with this shift, progress was slow. India's defense, though more organized, still lacked the depth to compete against higher-quality teams, and the players—especially the younger ones—were finding it hard to secure consistent opportunities. Players like *Jithin MS* and *Vibin Mohanan*, who had been performing well in domestic leagues, were often overlooked in favor of more established faces. It felt like there was a ceiling, a reluctance to take risks and give youth a chance to shine.

This hesitancy is the warning signs and symptoms of a larger issue plaguing Indian football: the players' comfort with the ISL and the lack of incentive to push themselves further. In the ISL, top Indian players earn lucrative contracts that can range from 5–8 crore annually. For these players, the influence of playing in top European leagues - where the competition is fierce and the opportunities for growth are endless - often takes a backseat to the comfort of staying in India, where the money is good, the pressure is lower, and the matches are fewer.

The ISL's growing salary cap, which increased from 16.5 crore to 18 crore for the 2024–2025 season, only increases the problem. The rise in salaries has made it more tempting for players to settle in India, where they are guaranteed top-tier pay without the same level of intensity as the European leagues. And while this system has allowed players to enjoy a comfortable lifestyle, it also creates a slowdown that holds back both the individual players and Indian football as a whole. The fact remains that without testing themselves against the best, players will never reach their full potential.

It's a paradox: Indian footballers avoid playing in foreign leagues because they fear the drop in salary, but by staying in India, they risk falling behind the global curve. To truly improve and elevate Indian football, players need to embrace the challenges of competing in European leagues. Only through exposure to higher standards of competition can they develop the skills, mindset, and resilience needed to succeed on the world stage.

But the story of Indian football is not just about the players. It's about the system that's meant to nurture and grow the sport. Unfortunately, the All India Football Federation (AIFF) is also grappling with its own set of internal issues. The recent allegations of corruption against the federation's president, Kalyan Chaubey, have cast a dark shadow over the future of Indian football. The AIFF's principal legal advisor, Nilanjan Bhattacharjee, made a series of serious allegations, accusing Chaubey of manipulating tender processes and misusing federation funds for personal gain. These allegations are not just about financial mismanagement—they point to a deeper problem within Indian football's governance, where personal interests seem to outweigh the welfare of the sport itself.

Bhattacharjee's letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi was a powerful reminder of the internal rot that can so often go unnoticed in the chaos of on-field performance. Bhattacharjee accused Chaubey of using his position to allocate tenders for broadcasting services to a company with close ties to him, in exchange for personal benefits. The funds that were meant to develop the sport were allegedly spent on extravagant personal trips and hotel stays, with over 40 lakh allegedly spent on one of Chaubey's trips alone. These are serious claims that, if proven true, could tarnish the AIFF's reputation irreparably.

Despite these allegations, Chaubey remains defiant, dismissing the claims as baseless and vowing to pursue legal action. However, the damage has already been done. The AIFF, an institution meant to be the cornerstone of Indian football's progress, now finds itself embroiled in scandal and controversy. This lack of transparency, accountability, and vision at the highest levels only adds to the challenges that players, coaches, and fans already face.

As the corruption allegations unfold, it becomes increasingly clear that the problems within Indian football are not just about the players' performance on the pitch—they're about the system that's supposed to support them. The AIFF must not only clean up its act but also create a culture of accountability and transparency that will restore faith in the organization and the sport.

At the same time, India's youth development system remains a crucial point of concern. If Indian football is to have a future, it must start with grassroots development. There is a desperate need to establish more structured youth programs that provide aspiring players with the tools they need to succeed. These programs should focus on creating pathways for young talent to progress, offering them opportunities to play and compete at various levels, all while maintaining a strong focus on skill development and coaching.

But the real change will come when the Indian football community—players, coaches, administrators, and fans—starts looking beyond the present and imagining what could be. The road to success isn't just about fixing a few problems here and there; it's about a complete overhaul of the way football is approached in India. It's about creating a system that prioritizes development over comfort, ambition over complacency, and passion over politics.

For now, India's football story remains one of hope amid the struggles. The players, coaches, and fans are still waiting for the breakthrough that will take Indian football to the global stage. But to get there, everyone will need to play their part, whether it's on the pitch or in the boardroom. It will require hard decisions, tough conversations, and most importantly, a willingness to confront the uncomfortable truths that have been holding Indian football back for far too long. Only then will the dream of seeing India compete with the world's best teams become a reality.